

Summary: You shouldn't talk to customers

Narrative Summary

The speaker begins with a strong and controversial statement, expressing a personal dislike for interacting with customers and actively preventing colleagues from doing so. The core belief underpinning this stance is that customers inherently do not know what they truly want. This isn't due to malicious intent, but rather the nature of human decision-making.

The video explains that many purchasing and behavioral choices, such as what one buys or wears, are largely subconscious decisions. The fundamental problem arises when one attempts to consciously interrogate a subconscious process. When asked directly about their preferences or motivations, customers will inevitably provide conscious answers that, despite their best efforts, can be misleading because they are trying to articulate something that is not consciously understood by them.

To circumvent the unreliability of direct customer feedback, the speaker offers a rather unconventional but profound alternative for understanding human behavior. They assert that all essential insights into humans can be found in the works of Shakespeare. This suggests that a deep understanding of human nature, psychology, and motivations through timeless literature is far more valuable and accurate than any direct customer research.

Key Points

- The speaker strongly dislikes talking to customers and prevents colleagues from doing so.
- Customers generally do not know what they truly want.
- Purchasing and fashion choices are primarily subconscious decisions.
- Asking customers conscious questions about subconscious decisions yields misleading information.
- Direct customer research is often unreliable due to the subconscious nature of consumer choices.
- Understanding human behavior through literature, specifically Shakespeare, is deemed more effective than direct customer interaction or research.

Notable Quotes

- “I hate talking to customers. I refuse to allow colleagues of mine to talk to customers.” (0:00)
- “Customers don’t know what they want and they’re very bad because it’s a subconscious decision.” (0:03)
- “When you’re consciously trying to answer a subconscious decision, you actually give misleading information even when you’re trying.” (0:14)
- “Everything important you need to learn about humans was written by Shakespeare. Just read Shakespeare. Like that’s better than all the customer research.” (0:21)